class2 questions

Contents

Homework: Questions in Preface Section on *1984*, Disciplinary Surveillance, and Narrative Analysis splied with Slide: Bruner's Terms, Applied to Winston

- *Mental control often attempts to flatten a person's inner life. How does the narrative use the "intentional states" (private thoughts) of the characters to defy the external world?*
  - **Intentional states:** his private thoughts — the one place the telescreen can't see, until Room 101
- *In a "mentally controlled world," the system provides the "canonical script" (how one should think and act). How does the protagonist of our story create a "breach" in that script?*
  - **Canonical script:** the Party's version of how to think, act, and remember
  - **Breach:** the first word Winston writes in the diary
- *In propaganda-heavy worlds, "truth" is whatever the state says. How does a "tale of defiance" use "narrative truth" to expose the lies of "systemic truth"?*
  - **Narrative vs. systemic truth:** Winston's memory against the Ministry of Truth and the memory hole
- *Why do we often use the "Dystopian" genre to talk about mental control? How does the genre itself help us understand what "defiance" looks like?*
- *What helps or hurts the ability of individual acts of defiance "accrue" into a movement?*
  - **Accrual:** can private defiance add up to a movement? Julia, the Brotherhood, Goldstein's book — and why none of it accrues

Homework Questions following up on Fromm's Afterword, spliced with Slide: on Fromm's afterward

1. *Can the longing for freedom be extinguished, or does human nature push back, as a defiance to mind control?*
   In words that turn O'Briens statement of power into a question:

   Can a boot stamp on a human face forever? (slide title)

   - Slide: Central question: Can human nature be changed so we forget our longing for freedom, dignity, and love?
2. *Does the severity of the methods used by the state prove the strength of what they suppress?*
   Do severe methods actually increase the stength of the defiant?
   - Slide: Severity proves strength: A brain operation (We), drugs and breeding (BNW), unlimited torture (1984) – the cure shows how strong the striving is
3. Is history really written by the victors?
   Is truth written by those in power?

- Slide: The minority of one: When truth is whatever the Party says, a minority of one must believe he is insane – the outlier lens returns
- Slide: Doublethink is not just "them": Fromm insists 1984 "means us, too"

Also on Fromm slide: A fully dehumanized world would be a world of madmen – not a viable one

Powerpoint: Questions for the Room

1. The Underground Man was ignored; Winston is watched every minute. Which is lonelier?
2. Is secret writing to an unknown reader a kind of freedom? What happens when the words are taken away?
3. Can a society force 2 + 2 to equal 4, or 5 – or make it not matter at all?
4. Are you an outlier? Would you rather be ignored, diagnosed, removed, or hunted, broken, and rebuilt?
5. and 6. in fromm question 2 and 3.